

Visitors Laugh Away Troubles at the HaHaHouse Museum

A new museum of laughter in Croatia is offering to help people deal with the negativity of modern life.

Visitors to the HaHaHouse in the Croatian capital Zagreb walk into a little cloud of white smoke when they step inside. Its purpose is to blow away their worries before they climb into a "giant washing machine".

Then they move down a twisting slide into a space filled with little white balls where their trip to a happier place starts.

Forty-three-year-old Andrea Golubic is the museum's creator. Golubic said she got the idea during the COVID-19 pandemic. At that time, many people were feeling down, depressed and alone: "I realized that I had a mission -- to heal people with laughter."

The idea "came straight from the heart", Golubic told the French News Agency (AFP). She had ideas for many of the museum elements in one day: "that's how the HaHaHouse began."

Golubic said a picture of her when she was seven-year-old inspired her. "I was constantly joking as a kid," she added.

Visitors press a button to be "disinfected from negativity" as soon as they step inside the museum, which has eight interactive zones, or areas.

One has rubber chickens singing cheerfully. They sing songs like ABBA's "Dancing Queen." There is a karaoke room with distorted voices and a "Sumo Arena" for wrestling in puffed up clothes.

There is also some serious history of humor from ancient to modern times told through theatre, film or the internet.

The museum also explains different kinds of humor. These include word play, slapstick, dark humor and satire.

Museum founder Andrea Golubic poses inside a pool full of small white balls at the HaHaHouse museum of laughter in central Zagreb, on January 21, 2025. (Photo by Damir SENCAR / AFP)

Inner child

Golubic said the HaHaHouse is popular with everyone from small children to older people. Adults say it is a good excuse to act like a child.

"All those who still feel a bit of childish joy and embrace their inner child, will recharge themselves," she said.

Retiree Bruno Dadic told AFP he was pleased by his visit "as there is never enough humor in life.

"Laughter is a medicine for the soul," he said.

Aleksandar Suka celebrated his fifth birthday with a visit. Visiting with his mother, the little boy said he liked lying on the "Bed of Nails" since they tickled him.

Singer Zorica Bucic, from the coastal town of Split, said the museum was just right for our times.

"Entering here is like entering childhood, being relieved of all problems," she said. Bucic added that if you could come to museum often, you would not need to visit a psychologist.

Psychologist Petar Kraljevic told AFP that laughter is a kind of weapon which gives people strength to face their problems. He said that if doctors could advise their patients to have "three hours of laughter" a day, people would feel much better.

I'm John Russell.

Lajla Veselica reported this story for Agence-France Press. Jill Robbins adapted it for Learning English.

Vocabulary

museum - n. พิพิธภัณฑ์ - อาคารที่จัดแสดงนิทรรศการมากมายที่เกี่ยวข้องกับเรื่องราวต่างๆ เช่น ประวัติศาสตร์ ศิลปะ หรือเรื่องอื่นๆ ที่ผู้คนสนใจ

negativity - n. การคิดลบ -ทัศนคติที่คนมองเห็นแต่ข้อเสียของบางสิ่งบางอย่าง

twist - v. บิด, หักเลี้ยว - การโค้งหรืออหรือเปลี่ยนทิศทางอย่างกะทันหัน

inspire - v. บั่นดาลใจ - ทำให้ (บางคน) ต้องการทำบางสิ่งบางอย่าง; ทำให้ (บางคน) เกิดความคิดเกี่ยวกับสิ่งที่ควรทำหรือสร้างสรรค์

interactive - adj. แบบโต้ตอบ - ที่ออกแบบมาให้ตอบสนองต่อการกระทำหรือคำสั่งของผู้ใช้

karaoke - n. คาราโอเกะ - กิจกรรมยามว่างที่ผู้คนร้องเพลงตามดนตรีของเพลงยอดนิยม

slapstick - n. ตลกเง็บตัว - การแสดงตลกที่เกี่ยวข้องกับการกระทำทางกายภาพ (เช่น การล้มหรือการตีคน)

satire - n. การเสียดสี - วิธีการใช้มุกตลกเพื่อแสดงให้เห็นว่าบางคนหรือบางสิ่งโง่เขลา อ่อนแอ หรือไม่ดี; อารมณ์ขันที่แสดงถึงจุดอ่อนหรือข้อเสียของบุคคล รัฐบาล สังคม ฯลฯ

embrace - v. เปิดรับ, โอบกอด - การยอมรับ (บางสิ่งหรือบางคน) อย่างเต็มใจหรือยินดี

recharge - v. ชาร์จพลัง, เต็มพลัง - การพักผ่อนและผ่อนคลายเพื่อฟื้นคืนพลังงานและความแข็งแรง

tickle - v. จิกจี้ - การทำให้ (บางคน) หัวเราะโดยการสัมผัสส่วนที่ไวต่อความรู้สึกของร่างกายเบาๆ ด้วยนิ้ว
ขนนก หรือสิ่งที่คล้ายกัน

psychologist - n. นักจิตวิทยา - ผู้เชี่ยวชาญด้านสุขภาพที่โดยปกติไม่ใช่แพทย์ แต่มีเป้าหมายในการรักษา
ผู้ที่มีปัญหาด้านจิตใจหรือพฤติกรรม

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the main purpose of the new museum of laughter in Croatia?

- A) To showcase ancient Croatian history.
- B) To provide a space for quiet meditation.
- C) To help people deal with the negativity of modern life.
- D) To offer a platform for new artists.

2. What is the initial experience for visitors entering the HaHaHouse?

- A) They are given a map of the museum.
- B) They walk into a little cloud of white smoke.
- C) They immediately enter the 'Sumo Arena'.
- D) They are greeted by singing rubber chickens.

3. After the 'giant washing machine,' what is the next step for visitors in the museum?

- A) They listen to a history of humor.
- B) They enter a karaoke room.
- C) They move down a twisting slide into a space filled with little white balls.
- D) They press a button to disinfect from negativity.

4. Who is the creator of the HaHaHouse, and what significant event initially inspired her to create it?

- A) Bruno Dadic; his retirement.
- B) Andrea Golubic; the COVID-19 pandemic.
- C) Aleksandar Suka; his fifth birthday.
- D) Zorica Bucic; her singing career.

5. What did Andrea Golubic identify as her 'mission' during the COVID-19 pandemic?

- A) To travel the world.
- B) To become a psychologist.
- C) To heal people with laughter.
- D) To document the history of humor.

6. How quickly did Andrea Golubic develop many of the initial ideas for the museum?

- A) Over several years.
- B) In just one day.
- C) After extensive research.
- D) With the help of a large team.

7. Besides the pandemic, what personal memory also inspired Andrea Golubic?

- A) A dream she had as an adult.
- B) A picture of her seven-year-old self constantly joking.
- C) Her experience performing slapstick comedy.
- D) A visit to another laughter museum.

8. What specific action do visitors take upon entering the museum to be 'disinfected from negativity'?

- A) They sing a cheerful song.
- B) They press a button.
- C) They wear puffed up clothes.
- D) They engage in word play.

9. How many interactive zones does the HaHaHouse feature?

- A) Five
- B) Seven
- C) Eight
- D) Ten

10. Which of the following is NOT mentioned as an interactive zone or activity within the HaHaHouse?

- A) Rubber chickens singing.
- B) A karaoke room with distorted voices.
- C) A 'Sumo Arena' for wrestling.
- D) A virtual reality gaming zone.

11. In addition to interactive zones, what other educational content does the museum offer?

- A) Lessons on how to tell jokes.
- B) Serious history of humor from ancient to modern times.
- C) Workshops on positive thinking.

D) Guides for professional comedians.

12. Which type of humor is NOT explicitly mentioned as being explained in the museum?

- A) Word play
- B) Slapstick
- C) Observational comedy
- D) Satire

13. According to Golubic, who is the target audience for the HaHaHouse?

- A) Primarily adults seeking stress relief.
- B) Only young children.
- C) People of all ages, from small children to older people.
- D) Tourists from outside Croatia only.

14. What does Golubic believe visitors will achieve if they 'embrace their inner child' at the museum?

- A) They will learn new comedic skills.
- B) They will recharge themselves.
- C) They will become professional humorists.
- D) They will forget their names.

15. What reason did retiree Bruno Dadic give for being pleased with his visit to the museum?

- A) He found new friends.
- B) He enjoyed the food.
- C) He believed there is never enough humor in life and laughter is medicine for the soul.
- D) He won a prize.